

After Action Review:

Ecuador Earthquake

April – October 2016



Empowered lives.
Resilient nations.



Boosting women entrepreneurship through economic recovery. Photo credits: Gabriela Ullauri

Strengths of the Response

Reaction of Ecuador Country Office

Although the Country Office was moderately prepared to face an emergency, it reacted quickly to the crisis by establishing a Crisis Response Team composed of staff members, selected by their skill sets, to deliver an effective response. The quickness in the establishment of a field office in Manta, close to the national response coordination structures, was a key strategic decision that facilitated coordination and implementation of activities.

Innovative Communications Campaign

UNDP was rapid and effective in completing the three-week communications campaign titled “Ecuador Aquí Estoy!”. Using the innovative approach, awarded two Effie Prizes in 2017, that was oriented to non-traditional resource mobilization, the campaign was noted to be very successful.

UNDP Crisis Board Response

UNDP’s Crisis Board activated a Level 2 response for the Country Office and First Responders were quickly deployed. Significant support and resources were provided to the Country Office to reorient its programmatic efforts, strengthen operational capacities, and implement its recovery strategy.

SURGE Support and Corporate Mechanisms: Including, Exigency Measures

Corporate crisis response mechanisms, such as the Standard Operating Procedure, deployment of First Responders, SURGE planning and implementation, were useful in supporting the Country Office in delivering its response to the crisis.

UNDP has conducted an After Action Review (AAR) of its response to the 7.8 earthquake that struck the Northwestern provinces of Ecuador in April 2016. The loss of human life and material damage were considerable, with 671 deaths, 218,000 individuals affected, and 16,185 houses damaged and destroyed.

Additionally, community infrastructure was destroyed, impacting the local economies while leaving thousands of families without any subsistence or opportunities to rebuild their lives.

The recovery strategy positioned UNDP among different stakeholders, enabling resource mobilization from non-traditional partners like the private sector. These efforts helped UNDP develop a robust inclusive economic recovery portfolio, transitioning from an emergency to a recovery context, with a focus on sustainable value chain recovery, innovative solutions, entrepreneurship and institutional strengthening.

This review includes feedback from national and subnational stakeholders, from the UNDP Country Office, Regional and Headquarters levels, to donors and partners.

Innovation and adaptation of programmatic tools

The Ecuador experience represents an interesting case of innovation and adaptation of existing livelihood programming methodologies (En Marcha! and Creciendo con Su Negocio) in an emergency context. Fostered by a strong collaboration between the Country Office and the SURGE team, the packages developed are easily replicable and have been used recently in other emergency contexts, like Haiti and Mexico. With some additional adjustments (including addressing the gender dimension), they could become part of UNDP’s Crisis Response Package for Resilient Livelihoods.

Progressive professionalization of UNDP’s response capacity

UNDP’s progressive professionalization on crisis response is bearing fruits: corporate tools and mechanisms are effective in supporting a Country Office, with limited preparedness and experience in crisis management, to deliver. UNDP should keep investing in the development and maintenance of corporate tools and mechanisms to support country offices responding to crisis. This should include developing the capacity for UNDP staff to be deployed.

Sustainability

The Country Office leveraged existing capacities by working with national experts as much as possible and made efforts to strengthen national capacities by pairing national and international experts to ensure a transfer of knowledge and sustainability.

Challenges and gaps

Early Recovery (ER) coordination

Despite the progress made over the years, the acceptance of early recovery remains a challenge in crisis contexts; limiting the cluster's space, priority and resources. To this effect, the results of the 2016 World Humanitarian Summit and the renewed commitment of the international community to transcend the humanitarian and development nexus represent an opportunity to ensure the integration of early recovery into crisis responses.

At the cluster level, UNDP was effective with its responsibilities of national coordination, information management, and contribution to humanitarian appeals. However, the Country Office was less effective in other areas. For example, there was no sector-wide assessment on early recovery needs with an ensuing plan of action, and after a while, the sector lost some traction among its partners.

Gender equality

UNDP's projects ensured the inclusion of a significant percentage of women as beneficiaries. However, UNDP could try to address gender issues more systematically. The AAR found that there was a lack of comprehensive gender analysis in the assessments, including, in the PDNA. Furthermore, the recovery projects could have more thoroughly addressed the different impact of the crisis on women and men and how UNDP's interventions could contribute to reduce gender inequality.

Limited crisis preparedness

The Country Office had conducted some internal and interagency preparedness activities. However, many of its staff had not been previously exposed to or trained in crisis response. The organization should take measures at corporate and regional levels to support Country Offices in strengthening their preparedness to face emergencies.

Resource mobilization

Due to the limited resource mobilization opportunities in middle income countries like Ecuador, UNDP used innovative approaches to mobilize resources from private sector and other non-traditional partners.

Moving forward

The AAR concludes that the Country Office benefitted from the corporate support provided, and that UNDP benefits from the expertise developed and tools created for crisis response. Moving forward, the organization should invest further in improving its performance on crisis response, early and long-term recovery.

UNDP should continue its professionalization in these areas and strategically invest resources to become the global leader on its signature areas of expertise.

UNDP should factor in the findings on early recovery coordination when implementing the recommendations of the Global Cluster for Early Recovery Evaluation.

UNDP should engage in a more systematic approach to gender equality and women's empowerment in crisis response and early recovery.

In May 2016, UNDP started cash for work activities focusing on debris management and rehabilitating community productive infrastructure.



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United Nations Development Programme
One United Nations
Plaza New York, NY,
10017 USA